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Website: https://journals.lww.com/jehp/
DOI: 10.4103/jehp.jehp_909_25

Psychological resilience as a buffer against climate change anxiety in Iraqi youth

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Abstract:

BACKGROUND: Iraq is classified as the fifth most vulnerable country to the impacts of climate change, with a predominantly young population. While climate change anxiety is globally recognized, little is known about its impact on Iraq. Understanding its effect is important for nursing professionals, who promote youth mental health. This study aims to assess the correlations between climate change anxiety and psychological resilience among Iraqi youth.

MATERIAL AND METHODS: A descriptive cross-sectional correlational design with purposive sampling was employed using an online form. The study recruited 524 individuals living across 18 Iraqi governorates. The Arabic Versions of Climate Change Anxiety Scale and the Brief Resilience Scale were used to collect data between January 1 to February 20, 2025. Single-variable analysis used frequency and percentage to characterize categorical data, while mean and standard deviation were utilized for numerical data. Spearman's rank test was used to assess the relationship between climate change anxiety and psychological resilience.

RESULTS: Climate anxiety levels were found to be low in 73.8% of the participants, moderate in 24.1%, and high in 2.1%. In addition, 86.5% had a moderate level of psychological resilience. There was a statistically significant negative relationship between climate anxiety and psychological resilience ($P < 0.01$).

CONCLUSIONS: Nearly a quarter of Iraqi youth reported moderate climate anxiety. The negative relationship between climate anxiety and resilience highlights the importance of nursing-facilitated mental health interventions that target resilience to counter the climate change-related mental distress.

Keywords:

Anxiety, climate change, Iraq

Introduction

A widespread scientific agreement exists that climate change poses an existential threat to mankind and life on Earth. Climate change is a worldwide concern that has already adversely affected the environment and human health, resulting in heightened intensity and frequency of extreme weather events, including heat waves, droughts, and flooding.^[1] The public health consequences of the environmental and climatic disasters have historically concentrated on physical health effects, but during the past decade,

the perspective has expanded to recognize the significant mental health consequences faced by a growing number of individuals globally.^[2] Youth is the riskiest phase of young people's lives since it defines their destiny. It is a tough period for them, and coping with problems, anxieties, and the start of puberty.^[3] Latest research suggests that the existential danger of climate change may correlate with negative mental health effects, especially in younger demographics, and recent investigations have identified the phenomenon of climate change anxiety.^[4]

Before 2020, the phenomenon most frequently compared with climate anxiety

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How to cite this article: Jered JA, Alwan IH. Psychological resilience as a buffer against climate change anxiety in Iraqi youth. J Edu Health Promot 2026;15:44.

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Received: 15-05-2025
Accepted: 29-07-2025
Published: 30-01-2026

was worry of nuclear war. However, after that, the COVID-19 anxiety was possibly closer.^[5] The worldwide community was anxious about COVID-19 and has examined its impact on several aspects of life.^[6] For instance, anxiety prevalence was 39.4% in Iraq during the pandemic.^[7]

The emotional reactions caused by COVID-19 at that time may have negatively damaged persons with mental health difficulties as well,^[8] which, in turn, highlighted the need to educate young people on the necessity for a humanitarian response in society to those impacted by mental health difficulties.^[9]

While climate anxiety is not categorized as a form of anxiety disorder, in general, it should not be labeled as a mental disorder^[10] like, for example, social anxiety,^[11] nor as a result of chronic disease.^[12] Every individual responds to stress in various ways.^[13] However, Climate Change Anxiety (CCA) is characterized by adverse reactions linked to apprehensions of climate change.^[14,15] In addition, cognitive, emotional, and behavioral responses may manifest, including chronic anxiety, psychological distress, or sleep disturbances associated with the long-term effects of climate change, potentially leading to operational impairment, such as when climate change anxiety impedes a person's ability to fully participate in work, education, or interpersonal relationships.^[16] There are increasing global studies on the psychological effects of climate change anxiety.^[15,17-19] According to our readings, there are no studies that focused explicitly on its influence on the mental health of Iraqis. Previous research determined that further study regarding climate anxiety or eco-anxiety is necessary for underrepresented communities.^[20]

Psychological resilience is an essential concept relevant to people's lives since the obstacles and demands of life are evident throughout all nations. These obstacles and pressures intensify because of the characteristics of the prevailing circumstances in all societies, including Iraqi society.^[21] Luthans defines psychological resilience as "the developable capacity to rebound or bounce back from adversity, conflict, and failure or even positive events, progress, and increased responsibility."^[22] Its function in alleviating the psychological effects of trauma^[23] and its preventive influence versus the onset of mental health issues are considered.^[24] Since mental health practitioners, particularly nurses, play a crucial role in addressing the effects of climate change on mental health,^[25] knowing the association between psychological resilience and climate anxiety is important, especially in the Iraqi context. To our knowledge, this is the first study to examine the relationship between climate change anxiety and psychological resilience in Iraq. It contributes novel data from an underrepresented

population, highlighting the importance of mental health resilience strategies in this climate change and conflict-affected region.

Materials and Methods

Study design and setting

A descriptive cross-sectional correlational design was employed to determine the relationship between climate change anxiety and psychological resilience among Iraqi youth. The study was conducted entirely online in all 18 governorates of Iraq.

Study participants and sampling

The study was conducted from January 1 to February 20, 2025. The study employed nonprobability purposive sampling to obtain representative and accurate data. The study recruited (524) individuals living across 18 Iraqi governorates. Individuals outside the age range of 15 to 24 were excluded from the study, with a total of (80); those with diagnosed psychiatric disorders (26) were excluded as well; then 40 were employed in the pilot study; thus, the actual number of those participating in the study was 377. The sample size was calculated. According to the Raosoft sample calculator,^[26] the total recommended sample size is 385 with a 95% confidence level, 5% margin of error, and 8,021,531 population size. The population size was 8,021,531 according to population estimation of Iraq by age groups (15–24) for the year 2020.^[27]

Data collection tool and technique

- Part I – Demographic data form: This part involves collecting demographic information from the participants, including age, sex, level of education, and monthly income.
- Part II – Climate Change Anxiety Scale (CCAS): The CCAS, originally developed by authors,^[16] is a 13-item self-report questionnaire designed to evaluate climate change anxiety as a psychological response to climate change. Participants evaluated the degree to which the CAS statements accurately reflect their experiences using a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (never) to 5 (almost always). Fekih-Romdhane *et al.* translated the CCAS into Arabic and assessed its psychometric qualities, indicating that the Arabic CCAS is appropriate for use as a self-report instrument for CCA among Arabic-speaking people.^[28]
- Part III – The Brief Resilience Scale (BRS): The BRS, initially created by Smith *et al.*, consists of six components with total scores that range from 6 to 30. It consists of six items with total scores varying from 6 to 30. Participants rate each statement using a scale of 1 = strongly disagree, 2 = disagree, 3 = neutral, 4 = agree, or 5 = strongly agree. The primary aim of this test is to assess an individual's capacity to cope

under stressful conditions.^[29] Baattaiah *et al.* translated the scale into Arabic and reported the reliability and validity of the Arabic version of the BRS for application in research and therapeutic environments with the Arabic-speaking population.^[30]

To check both face and content validity, the questionnaire was thoroughly reviewed by a team of seven experts from different fields—academics at the Universities of Baghdad, Al-Qadisiyah, and Karbala, along with psychiatric experts who work at the Al-Hayat Mental Health Hospital. The overall feedback received was positive regarding the simplicity, relevance, and adequacy of the items incorporated. Due to their suggestions, some minor changes were made, particularly to the demographic part.

Reliability was assessed through a pilot study with 40 participants. The CCAS of 13 items showed very good internal consistency, with a Cronbach's alpha of 0.879. The Psychological Resilience Scale of 6 items showed good reliability, with a Cronbach's alpha of 0.722. The online questionnaire was developed using Microsoft Forms to facilitate efficient data collection and increase accessibility for participants from various geographic areas.

Ethical considerations

The research protocol has been approved by the University's Research Ethics Committee (Ref: 16, Date 6/11/2024). Every participant provided their informed consent before data collection, and all participant information was kept anonymous throughout the research.

Statistical analysis method

Frequency and percentage were used to characterize categorical data, while mean and standard deviation were utilized for numerical data. The variables of climate change anxiety and psychological resilience scores exhibited abnormal distribution, as shown by the Kolmogorov–Smirnov test with $P < 0.05$. Spearman's rank test was used to assess the relationship between climate change anxiety and psychological resilience, with $P < 0.05$ being statistically significant. Correlation coefficients (r) were calculated to evaluate the direction and strength of the relationship. The dataset underwent a comprehensive analysis and interpretation employing the Statistical Package for Social Sciences (SPSS), version 26.0 (IBM Corporation, Armonk, NY, USA).

Results

This section provides a descriptive examination of the sociodemographic characteristics of Iraqi youth, describes their levels of climate change anxiety and

psychological resilience, and determines the relationship among these variables.

Sociodemographic characteristics of the study participants

Table 1 displays the sociodemographic details of the 377 respondents who completed the survey.

Table 1 presents the descriptive analysis of sociodemographic characteristics of Iraqi youth participants. The findings indicate that the average age for participants is 19.8 ± 2.3 years, with the highest percentage falling within the age group of 19–20 years (30.8%), followed by those in the 17–18 years age group (27.3%). The sex of participants is approximately equal for both sexes, with a slight predominance of males (50.1%) over the females (49.9%). In terms of education level, 30.8% had completed at least secondary education, 5.6% held a diploma, and the majority (62%) were pursuing or had obtained a bachelor's degree. Only 1.6% reported postgraduate education. Concerning monthly income, 45.9% of participants perceived their income as sufficient, 45.4% perceived it as barely sufficient, and only 8.8% perceived it as insufficient.

Climate Change Anxiety among Iraqi youth

According to Table 2, the majority of youth (73.8%) reported a low level of climate change anxiety with a mean score of mean $\pm$ standard deviation (SD) = 25.06 ± 9.061 . In comparison, 24.1% exhibited a

Table 1: Sociodemographic characteristics of the study participants ($n=377$)

Characteristics	Frequency (%)
Age (year), mean $\pm$ SD=19.8 $\pm$ 2.3	
15–16	24 (6.4)
17–18	103 (27.3)
19–20	116 (30.8)
21–22	77 (20.4)
23–24	57 (15.1)
Total	377 (100)
Sex	
Male	189 (50.1)
Female	188 (49.9)
Total	377 (100)
Level of education	
$\leq$ Secondary school	116 (30.8)
Diploma	21 (5.6)
Bachelor	234 (62)
Postgraduate	6 (1.6)
Total	377 (100)
Perceived monthly income	
Sufficient	173 (45.9)
Barely sufficient	171 (45.4)
Insufficient	33 (8.8)
Total	377 (100)

SD=Standard deviation

moderate level of climate anxiety, while only 2.1% displayed a high level of climate change anxiety.

Psychological resilience among Iraqi youth

Table 3 indicates that the majority of Iraqi youth (86.5%) demonstrated a moderate level of psychological resilience, with a mean score of mean $\pm$ SD = 19.05 $\pm$ 2.811. Additionally, 4.2% showed low resilience, while only 9.3% exhibited a high level of resilience.

This table shows that there is a statistically significant negative correlation between resilience and anxiety ($r = -0.198$, $P < 0.001$), indicating that lower levels of resilience are associated with higher levels of climate change anxiety and vice versa.

Discussion

The demographic profile of the participants, such as age, is consistent with prior youth-based research, reinforcing the representativeness and validity of the sample. For example, similar findings were reported in a study published in the Educational and Developmental Psychologist Journal Specialities in 2022, where the mean age of 452 Filipino youth participants was 19.18 years.^[31] This highlights the importance of tailoring interventions to meet the developmental and psychological needs of this age.

The relatively equal distribution of male and female participants reflects balanced representation and allows for broader interpretation of psychological trends in youth populations. Notably, these results align with those from a previous study that attempted to assess psychological and emotional responses to climate change among young people and sex-related differences. In that study, 51.4% of respondents were male, while 48.6% were female.^[32]

Table 2: Overall assessment of climate change anxiety among Iraqi youth

Climate anxiety	Frequency (%)	M $\pm$ SD	Ass.
Low	278 $\pm$ 73.8	25.06 $\pm$ 9.061	Low anxiety
Moderate	91 $\pm$ 24.1		
High	8 $\pm$ 2.1		
Total	377 $\pm$ 100		

M=Mean for the total score, SD=Standard deviation for the total score, Ass: Assessment, low=13–30.33, Moderate=30.34–47.66, High=47.67–65

Table 3: Overall assessment of psychological resilience among Iraqi youth

Resilience	Frequency (%)	M $\pm$ SD	Ass.
Low	16 (4.2)	19.05 $\pm$ 2.811	Moderate
Moderate	326 (86.5)		
High	35 (9.3)		
Total	377 (100)		

M=Mean for total score, SD=Standard deviation for total score, Ass=Assessment, low=6–14, moderate=14.1–22, high=22.1–30

Regarding participants' level of education, the largest proportion of youth (62%) had a Bachelor's degree or were pursuing one. At the same time, those who had secondary school education or below accounted for 30.8% of the sample, followed by diploma holders at 5.6%. Participants with postgraduate education represented the smallest group, comprising only 1.6%. Comparable results were reported in a study examining the relationship between depressive symptoms, climate change distress, and social norms in relation to climate change activism, in which 60% of participants held a bachelor's degree or higher.^[33] This indicates that the majority of Iraqi youth who participated are highly educated.

Regarding monthly income, 45.9% of participants considered their income sufficient, 45.4% considered it barely sufficient, and only 8.8% viewed it as insufficient. Similar findings were observed in a study conducted in several Iraqi governorates, which reported 48.9% of participants had sufficient income, 43.5% had barely sufficient income, and just 7.6% just insufficient income.^[34]

Data that are present in Table 2 revealed that a large proportion of youth (73.8%) experienced a low level of climate change anxiety, with a mean score of (mean $\pm$ SD = 25.06 $\pm$ 9.061). In comparison, 24.1% displayed a moderate level of anxiety. Conversely, 2.1% reported a high level of climate change anxiety. This result aligns with the results of Clayton and Karazsia.^[16] Their findings indicated that the prevalence of climate change anxiety was rather low in their American samples, with only a minority of subjects exhibiting high scores. Other studies applying the CCAS indicated low levels within the samples as well.^[15] Nevertheless, the prevalence levels were notably higher in two studies from the Philippines.^[31,35]

In the Iraqi context, various possible factors can apply. People might prioritize short-term societal, economic, and political concerns over environmental concerns in the long run. Cultural influences and mass media exposures can also influence perceptions, making the phenomenon either an individual matter or an intangible matter. Cultural aspects, like religious or traditional beliefs, might also play a role in reducing climate change anxiety.

Table 3 demonstrates that the majority of Iraqi youth (86.5%) presented moderate resilience, with a mean score of (mean $\pm$ SD = 19.05 $\pm$ 2.811); 4.2% displayed low resilience, while only 9.3% exhibited high resilience. The results of this study align with prior findings among undergraduate students in China. In the cross-sectional study, a randomly selected sample of 1743 undergraduate

students from six universities across three cities in Shandong Province was analyzed. The study reported an average psychological resilience score of 70.41,^[36] which is consistent with resilience levels observed in the current research. The moderate psychological resilience seen in Iraqi youth can be attributed to a combination of sociocultural, environmental, and economic factors. Prolonged conflict, financial hardships, and political unrest have greatly impacted their adaptive strategies.

Table 4 presents the correlations among climate change anxiety and psychological resilience in Iraqi youth. This indicates there is a statistically significant negative correlation between psychological resilience and climate anxiety ($r = -0.198$, $P < 0.001$).

Moreover, these findings complement the existing body of research on resilience as a protective factor against anxiety. Several studies found similar results, suggesting a statistically significant but weak negative correlation between resilience and anxiety. In prior research, resilience also had a significant negative correlation ($r = -0.23$, $P < 0.001$) with eco-anxiety.^[37]

The acquired data appear to corroborate prior findings, suggesting that resilience serves as a beneficial resource for safeguarding mental health. The positive psychology perspective argues that resilience is a human resource and suggests that, rather than managing mental conditions, fostering psychological resilience serves as an alternative means of safeguarding and promoting mental health.^[38,39] Intervention programs based on positive psychology and listening to Quran or music have demonstrated an anxiety reduction as well as an enhancement of health-related factors.^[40,41]

Limitations and recommendations

The study could not reach those in areas without Internet coverage. Purposive sampling was used in the study, which might not have produced a representative sample of all young Iraqis. This limit may have an impact on how broadly the results can be applied. The cross-sectional approach merely gives a glimpse of the prevalent psychological resilience and climate anxiety among Iraqi youth. Additionally, it is possible

that over- or under-reporting of climate change anxiety and psychological resilience resulted from the use of self-reported data.

Conclusions

This study examined the relationship between climate change anxiety and psychological resilience among Iraqi youth. This was the first study conducted to predict climate anxiety among Iraqi youth. Findings indicated that most Iraqi youth experienced low levels of climate change anxiety, while almost a quarter (24.1%) of them had moderate levels, with only a small percentage (2.1%) reporting high anxiety.

The majority of participants demonstrated moderate psychological resilience. Although statistical associations do not aim to fully elucidate causation, the underlined statistical association should not be disregarded. A negative correlation between psychological resilience and climate anxiety was found. This suggests that higher resilience helps mitigate climate anxiety levels, providing a clear scientific justification and indicating possible applications and extensions. Follow-up studies should address the qualitative aspects of climate-change anxiety among Iraqi youth to gain a better understanding of their coping strategies and emotional response. Given the observed association between resilience and climate change anxiety, it is essential to implement nursing programs that address the issue of building psychological resilience in young people. Some of these programs can include stress management workshops, resilience-fostering programs, and psychological counseling that encompass nursing practice.

Acknowledgment

The author extends heartfelt gratitude to all participants for generously contributing their time and experiences to this study. Their support was essential to the completion of this research.

Financial support and sponsorship

Nil.

Conflicts of interest

There are no conflicts of interest.

Table 4: Correlation between climate change anxiety and psychological resilience among Iraqi youth ($n=377$)

Correlation	Psychological resilience	Climate change anxiety
Psychological resilience		
Spearman correlation	1	-0.198**
Significant (two-tailed)		0.000
Climate change anxiety		
Spearman correlation	-0.198**	1
Significant (two-tailed)	0.000	

**Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (two-tailed)

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